

Ecstatic: Verstappen celebrates with Red Bull team after the win. GETTY IMAGES

drivers' championship. What might have been a one- or two-point swing at best turned into a blessing in disguise when the two papaya cars collided at the first corner.

Piastrì had made a quick start from third on the grid but found no space on the inside going into the steep, left-handed first corner. The 24-year-old braked earlier than his teammate, hoping to switch back inside and pass him with better traction. Waiting for him at the corner, however, was the front end of Nico Hulkenberg's Kick Sauber, who was himself embroiled in a tussle with Aston Martin's Fernando Alonso. Piastrì bounced off Hulkenberg and into Norris, leaving both McLarens with terminal damage, and Verstappen with an eight-point advantage.

Piastrì's misery continued into qualifying. Struggling to deal effectively with the crosswinds that made life difficult in the twistier sections of the COTA circuit, the Aussie could only manage sixth on the grid, well behind his rivals, who locked out the front row. George Russell's poor getaway at the race start handed Piastrì fifth place on a platter, but that was all he could manage after 56 laps.

The Sprint Race also signalled the turn in fortunes for another team. After qualifying a disappointing eighth and tenth for the short-distance shootout, Ferrari's Lewis Hamilton and Charles Leclerc saw the track open up for them after the first-lap melee. The pair of scarlet red cars finished just shy of the podium—behind Verstappen, Russell and Williams' Carlos Sainz.

The Scuderia had a better outing in Qualifying for the main race — third for Leclerc and fifth for Hamilton. An offbeat call to fit red-walled soft tyres on Leclerc's car for the start paid dividends. The Monegasque, the only driver in the



top 15 to employ the strategy, gained better grip off the surface at the start and eased past Norris into second. Despite the tyre disadvantage, he held off the Briton for 21 laps and again until lap 51 after the pit stop, before the quicker McLaren eventually went ahead. Hamilton, who came close to passing his teammate just before his stop, had to settle for fourth, making him the first driver ever to register 5,000 points in Formula One.

This see-saw battle for second place allowed Verstappen to complete a serene victory despite the soaring Austin temperatures, which forced the organisers to issue a heat hazard warning. It seemed like the air of invincibility had returned around the Red Bull driver after his 122nd podium finish, placing him level with Sebastian Vettel (third) on the all-time list. As we head to Mexico City next week (October 24–26), it is well and truly squeaky-bum time for Piastrì and Norris, with the four-time champion hot on their heels.

MotoGP



An unfortunate incident with Marco Bezzecchi in Indonesia forced World Champion Marc Marquez to sit out the Australian Grand Prix at Phillip Island, with surgery required on his right shoulder. The Ducati rider has won 11 of 19 races this year, and with him out of contention in this race, it was an opportunity for someone to step out of his shadow and claim a premier-class win.

The less-heralded Raul Fernandez of Trackhouse Aprilia made the most of the opportunity, speeding to his and the team's maiden MotoGP victory. Sprint Race winner Bezzecchi, who was handed twin long-lap penalties for the Marquez crash, could only manage third for the Aprilia factory team, behind VR46 Racing Team's Fabio Di Giannantonio.